

CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 1 - Server Certificate Working Group

Compiled by the Spaced Research Ledger

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The Server Certificate Working Group writes the rules for the certificates that secure the public web. It is the busiest of the Forum's groups, and it published seven versions of its Baseline Requirements between November 2025 and August 2026.

This part covers three strands of its work. Section 1 tracks the ballots and the document versions they produce. Section 2 covers domain control validation, where the rules are tightening fastest. Section 3 covers certificate profiles and cryptography, including the validity schedule and the question of post-quantum keys.

One distinction governs everything below and is easy to lose. A ballot that passes its vote is not yet a requirement. It enters a 30-day intellectual property review, and only after that does the text publish into a numbered version. A further date, the effective date, decides when certificate authorities must actually comply. This report separates those states throughout, because conflating them produces confident statements about rules that do not yet bind anyone.

1. Ballots and Document Versions

The Baseline Requirements move by ballot. Each ballot that changes the text produces a numbered version, and the Forum publishes its own revision table, which is the authoritative record of what is in force.

Recent Developments

The current published version is 2.2.9, adopted by Ballot SC101v2 on 2 July 2026 and effective from 6 August 2026 [1]. It clarifies Authorization Domain Names [2]. The preceding versions arrived at a rapid pace. Version 2.2.8 came from Ballot SC098 and required processing of RFC 8657 CAA parameters [1]. Version 2.2.7 came from SC099 and improved how a certificate authority records which validation method it used [1].

Earlier in 2026 the group cleared a backlog. Version 2.2.6 was a general clean-up adopted by SC095 in February and effective 31 March 2026 [1]. Version 2.2.5, from Ballot SC097, sunsets all remaining use of SHA-1 signatures in certificates and revocation lists, with phased effective dates beginning 15 September 2026 [3]. Version 2.2.4, from SC096, created a carve-out for DNSSEC verification logging and took effect 17 February 2026 [1].

Redlined and clean copies of each version are maintained in the Forum's own repository alongside the published documents [4].

Current State

Four ballots sit in the pipeline at different stages. Ballot SC100, covering DNSSEC clarification and consolidation, passed its vote and is in intellectual property review from 6 August to 5 September 2026 [5].

Ballot SC102, on EV domain reuse and validity alignment, also passed, with its review running from 14 July to 13 August 2026 [6].

Ballot SC104, which would set the presence of the Authority Information Access extension to SHOULD for subscriber certificates, is in its voting period [7]. Ballot SC103, which would require Extended Key Usage extensions on cross-certified subordinate certificate authorities, remains in discussion with questions still open on the mailing list [7]. A further draft, SC105, would remove High Risk language from the Baseline Requirements and the EV Guidelines, and has not yet been balloted [7].

The voting margins on the two adopted ballots were decisive rather than close. SC100 drew 22 yes votes from certificate issuers with no votes against and none abstaining, alongside three yes votes from certificate consumers [5]. SC102 drew 19 yes votes from issuers and two from consumers, again with no opposition [6].

2. Domain Control Validation

Domain control validation is how a certificate authority satisfies itself that the applicant controls the name being certified. Three separate mechanisms are converging on one goal, which is to make control of a single network path insufficient to obtain a certificate.

Recent Developments

Multi-Perspective Issuance Corroboration became mandatory for all publicly trusted TLS certificates on 15 September 2025 under Ballot SC-067 [8]. It requires that domain validation and CAA checks be corroborated from geographically and topologically distinct network perspectives [8]. The purpose is to defeat attacks that manipulate one network path, including DNS response manipulation and route hijacking, by demanding the same answer from several vantage points [8].

The requirement arrives in stages rather than at full strength. Two corroborating perspectives were required from September 2025, three from March 2026, and four from June 2026, with five due by December 2026 [9]. That December step is the next one to land.

Ballot SC100 consolidates DNSSEC rules that were scattered through the document into a new Section 4.2.2.2 [5]. It also settles how DNSSEC and multi-perspective validation interact, clarifying that DNSSEC validation may be performed on remote network perspectives but is required only on the primary one [5]. Because SC100 remains in review, that consolidated section is not yet published text [5].

Current State

The set of permitted validation methods is contracting. Ballot SC090, published as version 2.2.2 in November 2025, gradually sunsets the email-based and phone-based methods [1]. Version 2.2.3, from Ballot SC094, created a DNSSEC exception in the email methods that remain [1].

Reuse periods are contracting alongside validity. Ballot SC102 removes the WHOIS and RDAP same-registrant check from EV domain revalidation, and replaces hardcoded 398-day reuse values in the EV Guidelines with references to the Baseline Requirements [10]. The effect is that EV reuse now follows the general schedule automatically rather than needing its own amendment each time that schedule moves.

3. Certificate Profiles and Cryptography

This section holds the change with the widest operational reach, which is the staged reduction of certificate lifetimes. It also holds the question the industry is waiting on, which is when post-quantum keys become permissible.

Recent Developments

Ballot SC081v3 was published on 11 April 2025 and established a staged reduction of both certificate validity and data reuse periods rather than a single cutover [11]. Its first step is in force. Certificates issued on or after 15 March 2026 may not exceed 200 days, and domain validation reuse dropped to 200 days on the same date [11].

Two further steps are scheduled and not yet binding. Maximum validity falls to 100 days on 15 March 2027 and to 47 days on 15 March 2029. Domain validation reuse falls to 100 days and then 10 days on those same two dates [12].

Current State

Post-quantum signatures are not yet permitted in publicly trusted TLS certificates. Draft text to allow ML-DSA public keys and signatures exists as a pull request against the Forum's repository, covering the ML-DSA-44, ML-DSA-65 and ML-DSA-87 parameter sets [13]. It is draft text and has not entered any stage of the ballot lifecycle [13].

As of May 2026 no merged Baseline Requirement permitted ML-DSA. No public root certificate authority had issued an ML-DSA root chaining into the Mozilla, Apple, Microsoft or Chrome trust stores [14]. The working group has recorded that post-quantum certificate authentication has two blocking dependencies, and only one of them belongs to the Forum. The Baseline Requirements must be amended to permit ML-DSA, and the IETF must finalize the object identifier and encoding standards for post-quantum algorithms in X.509 [14].

Unresolved Conflicts

The Forum's own working groups are not moving together on post-quantum algorithms, and this section records only one side of that divergence. The Server Certificate group has draft text and no ballot. The S/MIME group published post-quantum algorithms into its requirements in August 2025, as Part 3 records.

The two groups govern different certificate profiles and need not move in step. This is a real difference in pace rather than a contradiction in the record. What would settle the question here is a numbered SC ballot entering discussion, which has not happened.

About This Report

The Spaced Research Ledger is an automated system that gathers claims from live public sources, checks each one against its origin, and records every disagreement instead of merging it. Every stage runs on a

different AI model, drawn from three to four systems across competing labs, so no single model both finds a claim and judges it. The Spaced Research Ledger is designed and maintained by Ridley DiSiena.

Sources

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